

Role Of Soft Skills In Your Engineering Career

The most common HR question is: Beyond technical skills, experience and knowledge, what added value do you bring to the organisation? Of course, it is the soft skills that ensure success in your career. Here is what exactly are soft skills, why they are needed and what you can do to improve your soft skills



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In India, electronics engineering as a career has always attracted the student community in a big way. Testimony to this fact is an ever-increasing number of aspirants taking various entrance exams to qualify and enroll for their choice of engineering branch. Throughout the course, one learns and specialises in a particular branch of engineering theoretically and practically. However, just technical skills are not enough as the most common HR question is: Beyond technical skills, experience and knowledge, what added value do you bring to the organisation? Therefore soft skills are critical to make you employable.

What exactly are soft skills?

Naresh Narasimhan, country marketing manager, Tektronix, says, "In the 21st century and going forward, three things are important—ability to communicate

an idea visually, ability to have a balanced point-of-view on key issues and ability to convert ideas to results."

The concept of soft skills is not limited to just plain communication skills but it also includes aspects such as people skills.

Dr Pallab Bandyopadhyay, director-HR, Citrix India, explains: "In the broader context, soft skills would also include negotiation, decision making, reasoning and problem solving, and conflict-resolution skills required in today's work environment."

"While technical professionals are often selected and trained based on measurable talents and skills such as knowledge of OS or software programming skills—which are prerequisites to starting a career in engineering and technology—intangible skills such as language proficiency, ability to work with global teams and positive attitude often count in making their career a rewarding one. These intangible skills are

classified as soft-skills," adds Sudhanshu Pandit, director-HR, Symantec India.

When evaluating a candidate on soft skills, HR professionals look at not only his ability to communicate his thoughts clearly and concisely but also his personality and problem-solving skills.

Defining soft skills, John Prohovsky, founder and principal consultant, Future Envisioned, says, "Soft skills are non-technical, interpersonal and communication skills required by an engineer to successfully solve problems and apply his technical skills."

Throwing light on how soft skills are directly proportional to one's personality, Rajesh Choudhary, HR head, Xilinx India, says, "Personality traits such as common sense, optimism, responsibility, integrity, attitude and behavioural competencies that include analytical thinking, result orientation and achievement, communication, teamwork, conflict management, customer orientation and attention to details come under soft skills."

As soft skills cover all the aspects related to human behaviour, Zubin Rashid, managing partner and head of training, ZRINDIA, believes that "Just as hard skills teach us about domain-specific skills like technology, products and processes, soft skills are about interacting with people with whom you work."

Every company looks for a different mix of skills and experience and it is not enough just to be a subject matter expert. Communication is an integral part of soft skills.

Surinder Bhagat, country HR head, Freescale Semiconductor, India, says, "Soft skills can also refer to a set of skills that determine how one interacts